

Lewis Downing to seek full term on Anniston Ward 1 councilman

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Lewis Downing is running for Ward 1 in the upcoming Anniston municipal elections on August 26.

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ANNISTON — Lewis Downing, a local business owner and longtime resident of Anniston, announced his candidacy for the Ward 1 seat on the Anniston City Council — a position he currently holds by appointment.

Downing was unanimously appointed by the council in December 2024 to fill the seat vacated by former Councilman Jay Jenkins, who stepped down in October. This marks Downing's first run for elected office.

"I grew up in Anniston," Downing wrote in an email. "I was born in Birmingham but we moved into a small house on 10th Street when I was just two. As it would turn out years later, that is the house that my wife and I lived in when we got married and had our first two children."



Downing, 40, attended multiple schools in the area including 10thStreet Elementary, White Plains High School and Anniston High School before graduating from Sacred Heart Catholic School in 2003. He went on to attend the University of Alabama and later Jacksonville State University while working at his family's business full time.

He is now the third-generation owner of Downing and Sons, a local retailer that has served the community since 1963, specializing in lawn and garden products, as well as upholstery and drapery supplies.

Downing said the decision to run for office followed several discussions with his family and a personal commitment to service as he approached a milestone birthday.

"About a year ago I made my mind up that I wanted to run for office. After several family meetings we decided that I would run for city council," he wrote. "I was always raised to serve, to do your part, to be an asset and not a liability. That always stuck with me."

"I want to be an asset," he continued. "I believe I've got a set of skills that I could put in place to benefit the city. I love this city — for all of its craziness, its beauty, its history and its people. I love this place. It's who I am and where I'm from."

As a council member, Downing said his top priority is continuing the work he began when appointed — advocating for the needs of Ward 1 residents and providing "fair, honest (sometimes painfully) representation."

He also emphasized the importance of responsibly developing McClellan, the site of the former U.S. Army installation.

"Development of McClellan is going to take honest, responsible leadership," he wrote. "This is a momentous task, but one I am certain we can handle. Proper development of the former Army post could propel Anniston far into the future and help ensure our prosperity and success well into the future."

Downing said he hopes to bring thoughtful leadership to the council, emphasizing empathy and deliberation in decision-making.

“I can listen to people and empathize with them,” he said. “I am not one to have knee-jerk reactions. I can think through problems and issues without reacting before I have all the information.”

Downing will be running against Benjamin New and John Squires in Anniston’s municipal election, which will be held August 26.

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